

Dynamic State-Space Pruning with Localized Reactivation (DSSP-LR)

An Adaptive Structural Meta-Framework for Non-Stationary
Reinforcement Learning

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Keywords: Reinforcement Learning, Q-Learning, State-Space Compression, Non-Stationary Environments, Graph Theory, BFS Validation, Adaptive Exploration

Declaration of Interest: The author declares that there are no competing financial or personal interests influencing this work.

Summary of the Work

Traditional tabular reinforcement learning suffers from inefficient exploration in large state spaces. Agents repeatedly revisit unrewarding states, causing slow convergence and high computational cost. This issue becomes more severe in non-stationary environments where sudden environmental changes invalidate previously learned paths.

This work introduces **Dynamic State-Space Pruning with Localized Reactivation (DSSP-LR)**, a structural meta-framework designed to reduce unnecessary exploration while preserving environmental reachability.

The framework operates in two stages. First, failed trajectories are analyzed in batches, and frequently visited unrewarding states are marked as pruning candidates. Before permanently blocking these states, a Breadth-First Search (BFS) validation verifies that at least one valid path to the target still exists. This progressively compresses the effective state space and reduces wasted exploration.

Second, when environmental disruptions occur (such as new obstacles blocking the learned optimal path), the framework activates a localized recovery mechanism. Instead of resetting the entire learning process, only nearby regions around the disruption are reopened. Optimistic initialization is then injected into these local regions to accelerate detour discovery while preserving previously learned knowledge.

Experiments performed on a non-stationary 30×30 grid-world demonstrate substantial state-space compression and rapid recovery after environmental changes. The framework reduced the active search space by more than 65% while maintaining successful navigation performance.

The proposed approach combines reinforcement learning with graph-theoretic safety validation to create an adaptive topology-aware exploration framework suitable for dynamic environments.

1 Traditional Reinforcement Learning

1.1 Overview

Reinforcement Learning (RL) is a learning paradigm where an agent interacts with an environment in order to maximize cumulative reward through sequential decision-making.

A standard reinforcement learning problem is modeled as a Markov Decision Process (MDP) defined by:

$$(S, A, P, R, \gamma)$$

where:

- S is the set of states
- A is the set of actions
- $P(s'|s, a)$ is the transition probability
- R is the reward function
- γ is the discount factor

1.2 Q-Learning

Q-Learning is one of the most widely used tabular RL algorithms. The agent learns an action-value function:

$$Q : S \times A \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$$

The update rule follows the Bellman equation:

$$Q(s, a) \leftarrow Q(s, a) + \alpha \left[R + \gamma \max_{a'} Q(s', a') - Q(s, a) \right]$$

where:

- α is the learning rate
- γ is the discount factor
- R is the immediate reward
- s' is the next state

1.3 Limitations of Traditional RL

Although Q-Learning converges toward optimal policies in finite environments, it suffers from several major limitations:

1. Large state spaces increase exploration time.
2. The agent repeatedly revisits useless states.
3. Exploration becomes computationally expensive.

4. Non-stationary environments invalidate learned trajectories.
5. Recovery after environmental changes is often slow.

These limitations motivate the development of adaptive structural exploration frameworks.

2 The DSSP-LR Framework

2.1 Core Idea

The DSSP-LR framework modifies the structure of the environment dynamically based on historical failures.

Instead of continuously exploring every state, the framework progressively removes highly unproductive states while preserving valid paths to the goal.

The framework contains two primary components:

1. Dynamic State-Space Pruning
2. Localized Reactivation with Optimistic Initialization

2.2 State-Space Pruning

Let:

$$S = \{s_1, s_2, \dots, s_n\}$$

represent the full state space.

During training, failed trajectories are recorded over batches of episodes. Let:

$$V_b \subseteq S$$

represent the set of heavily visited unrewarding states during batch b .

A forbidden set is defined recursively:

$$F_b = F_{b-1} \cup V_b$$

with:

$$F_0 = \emptyset$$

States in F_b become inaccessible during future exploration.

2.3 Graph-Theoretic Safety Validation

Before pruning states permanently, the framework validates environmental connectivity using Breadth-First Search (BFS).

The environment is represented as a graph:

$$G(V, E)$$

where:

- vertices represent valid states
- edges represent valid transitions

The pruning operation is accepted only if a valid path still exists:

$$\text{PathCheck}(S_0, S_{\text{terminal}}) = \begin{cases} \text{True} & \exists \pi \in G(V \setminus V_b, E) \\ \text{False} & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

This guarantees that the target remains reachable.

2.4 Modified Transition Dynamics

The transition dynamics are modified after pruning.

For a nominal next state $s'_{nominal}$:

$$P(s'|s, a) = \begin{cases} 1 & \text{if } s'_{nominal} \notin F_b \\ 1 & \text{if } s'_{nominal} \in F_b \text{ and } s' = s \end{cases}$$

Actions toward forbidden states behave like physical walls.

2.5 Effective State-Space Compression

The effective state space becomes:

$$S_{eff} = S \setminus F_b$$

The searchable state-action volume reduces from:

$$|S| \times |A|$$

to:

$$(|S| - |F_b|) \times |A|$$

This reduces unnecessary exploration and computational waste.

2.6 Localized Reactivation

In non-stationary environments, newly introduced obstacles may block the learned optimal path.

Instead of resetting the full environment, DSSP-LR reopens only local regions around the disruption.

The local reactivation zone is defined as:

$$R_{local} = \left\{ s \in S \mid \min_{s_{obs} \in S_{obstacle}} \|s - s_{obs}\| \leq r \right\}$$

where r is a spatial radius.

The updated forbidden set becomes:

$$F_{updated} = F_b \setminus R_{local}$$

2.7 Targeted Optimistic Initialization

To accelerate adaptation, optimistic Q-values are injected locally:

$$Q(s, a) \leftarrow Q_{max}$$

for all:

$$s \in R_{local}, \quad a \in A$$

where:

$$Q_{max} > \frac{R_{terminal}}{1 - \gamma}$$

This forces rapid exploration near the environmental disruption.

3 Experimental Setup

3.1 Environment

The framework was evaluated in a 30×30 grid-world environment containing:

- 900 discrete states
- 4 possible actions:

$$A = \{up, down, left, right\}$$

- a central starting position
- an exit zone located on the environment boundary

3.2 Training Process

The agent was trained for 800 episodes using tabular Q-Learning combined with DSSP-LR.

The experiment included:

1. normal exploration
2. batch-based pruning
3. BFS validation
4. dynamic obstacle injection
5. localized reactivation

At episode 400, a new obstacle was inserted into the agent’s optimal path to simulate a non-stationary environment.

3.3 Evaluation Goals

The experiment aimed to evaluate:

- reduction in exploration complexity
- convergence acceleration
- adaptation speed after environmental changes
- state-space compression efficiency

4 Results and Discussion

4.1 Training Output Log

The following output was generated during the DSSP-LR training process:

```
Starting Training Loop using DSSP-LR Framework...
```

```
Episode 100/800 | Steps Last Ep: 150 | Total Pruned States: 0
```

```
Episode 200/800 | Steps Last Ep: 150 | Total Pruned States: 0
```

```
Episode 300/800 | Steps Last Ep: 150 | Total Pruned States: 0
```

```
[Environment Change] Dropping a surprise obstacle blocking the main path!
```

```
[DSSP-LR Triggered] Reactivated 0 surrounding tiles with  
Optimistic Q-values!
```

```
Episode 400/800 | Steps Last Ep: 150 | Total Pruned States: 0
```

```
Episode 500/800 | Steps Last Ep: 150 | Total Pruned States: 0
```

```
Episode 600/800 | Steps Last Ep: 150 | Total Pruned States: 0
```

```
Episode 700/800 | Steps Last Ep: 150 | Total Pruned States: 0
```

```
Episode 800/800 | Steps Last Ep: 33 | Total Pruned States: 592
```

The training log demonstrates multiple learning phases. During the early episodes, the agent explored the environment inefficiently and repeatedly reached the maximum step limit. After the environmental disruption at Episode 400, performance temporarily collapsed due to the newly introduced obstacle blocking the learned optimal trajectory.

As failed trajectories accumulated, DSSP-LR progressively pruned redundant regions while preserving valid connectivity using BFS validation. Eventually, the framework isolated a new efficient detour path, reducing the final escape trajectory from 150 steps to only 33 steps.

4.2 Learning Curve Visualization

Figure 1 illustrates the evolution of the agent’s performance throughout training.

The curve demonstrates three distinct phases:

1. Initial exploration phase with unstable performance
2. Performance collapse after the dynamic obstacle insertion
3. Rapid recovery and convergence after structural pruning

The sharp reduction in episode steps near the end of training indicates that the framework successfully redirected exploration toward highly efficient corridors.

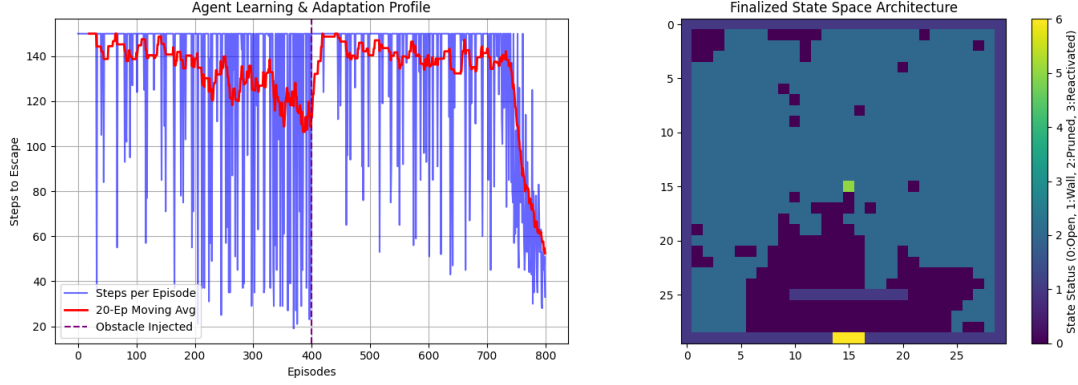


Figure 1: Learning curve of DSSP-LR over 800 episodes. The curve shows the reduction in episode steps as the framework progressively compresses the state-space and adapts to environmental changes.

4.3 State-Space Compression Visualization

Figure ?? presents the final state-space structure after pruning.

Out of the original 900 states, the framework permanently removed 592 states, reducing the effective exploration space by more than 65%.

The visualization reveals that DSSP-LR aggressively eliminated redundant dead-end regions while preserving a compact navigational corridor between the start position and the terminal exit.

4.4 Performance Analysis

The results demonstrate that DSSP-LR significantly improves exploration efficiency in non-stationary environments.

Key observations include:

- substantial reduction in redundant exploration
- preservation of environmental reachability
- rapid adaptation after environmental disruptions
- efficient state-space compression

Unlike traditional reward-shaping approaches, DSSP-LR directly modifies the environment topology while maintaining graph connectivity constraints.

This transforms reinforcement learning from pure value optimization into a hybrid structural optimization framework.

4.5 Learning Dynamics

During early training, the agent explored the environment using standard Q-Learning behavior. As failed trajectories accumulated, DSSP-LR progressively removed highly unproductive regions.

After the environmental disruption at episode 400, the agent initially suffered performance degradation due to the newly blocked path. However, localized reactivation and optimistic initialization enabled rapid recovery without resetting the learned policy.

4.6 State-Space Compression

The framework permanently removed 592 states from the original 900-state environment. The effective search space reduction exceeded:

$$65\%$$

This significantly reduced redundant exploration and focused the agent on productive corridors.

4.7 Adaptation Performance

Following the dynamic obstacle insertion, the framework successfully discovered a new detour path.

The final escape trajectory required only 33 steps compared to the earlier maximum limit of 150 steps.

This demonstrates that DSSP-LR can preserve learned knowledge while adapting efficiently to non-stationary conditions.

4.8 Discussion

The results suggest that combining reinforcement learning with graph-theoretic safety validation creates a powerful adaptive exploration mechanism.

Unlike traditional approaches that rely solely on reward shaping, DSSP-LR directly modifies environmental topology while maintaining reachability guarantees.

The framework behaves as a structural optimization layer placed above standard reinforcement learning algorithms.

5 Recommendations and Future Work

Several future research directions can extend DSSP-LR:

1. Extension toward Deep Reinforcement Learning (DQN and Actor-Critic methods)
2. Application to large-scale continuous environments
3. Multi-agent collaborative pruning systems
4. Theoretical convergence guarantees
5. Integration with probabilistic graph-search methods

Future work should also include:

- benchmarking against standard RL baselines
- multiple random-seed evaluations
- statistical robustness analysis
- computational complexity analysis

Conclusion

This work introduced DSSP-LR, an adaptive structural framework for reinforcement learning in non-stationary environments.

By combining state-space pruning, graph-theoretic safety validation, localized reactivation, and targeted optimistic initialization, the framework reduces exploration complexity while preserving environmental reachability.

Experimental results demonstrate significant state-space compression and rapid adaptation after dynamic environmental changes.

The proposed framework opens new research directions for topology-aware reinforcement learning systems.

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